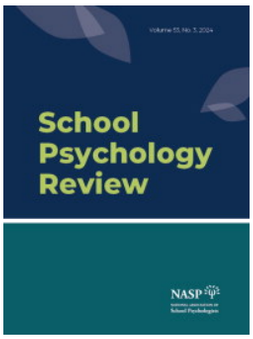

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EDITORIAL

Supporting Student Social Emotional Learning and Development

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ABSTRACT
In recent years, school psychology has increasingly recognized the importance of social-emotional health in achieving youth positive outcomes. Social-emotional skills, such as empathy, self-awareness, and responsible decision-making, are crucial for long-term academic and personal success. To help educators and school psychologists assess and promote students' social-emotional health, it is important to have a comprehensive understanding of this topic. This special section focuses on the significance of social-emotional skills and previous research on social-emotional learning (SEL) and their contributions and remaining questions. It includes seven contemporary articles on SEL-related school practices to enhance our understanding and suggest future directions for research and practice.

IMPACT STATEMENT
This paper discusses the theoretical and empirical foundations for social-emotional learning (SEL) and its significance on youth positive development. It also summarizes the scholarship included in this special topic section highlighting areas of opportunity to improve SEL research and practice for school-aged children and adolescents.

KEYWORDS
social-emotional learning (SEL), social-emotional health, SEL intervention, SEL assessment

In the fields of education and school psychology, the importance of addressing social-emotional development alongside academic proficiency has garnered increasing recognition (Anthony et al., 2022; Brann et al., 2022; CASEL, 2020; Cook, 2022; Kim & Choe, 2022; Kim et al., 2022; Lane, 2022; Pickens, 2022). School psychologists play a pivotal role in fostering an environment conducive to holistic student growth, encompassing cognitive, emotional, and social dimensions. The articles in this special topic section underscore the significance of prioritizing social-emotional development within the fields of education and school psychology, featuring insights from recent scholarship.

The contemporary educational landscape is marked by multifaceted challenges, ranging from academic stressors to socioeconomic disparities and mental health concerns (Bradshaw et al., 2021; Cho et al., 2021; Herman et al., 2021; Holmes et al., 2021; Reinke et al., 2021; Thompson et al., 2021). As highlighted by Elias et al. (1997), social-emotional competencies such as self-awareness, self-management, social awareness, relationship skills, and responsible decision-making are indispensable for navigating life's diverse contexts. Indeed, research underscores the profound impact of social-emotional competence on various facets of academic and personal achievement. According to Durlak et al. (2011), interventions targeting social-emotional learning (SEL) not only enhance students' social-emotional skills but also contribute to improved academic performance and reduced behavioral problems. Furthermore, these interventions have been shown to yield long-term benefits, including higher graduation rates and lower rates of substance abuse and criminal activity (CASEL, 2020).

In the context of school psychology, a comprehensive understanding of social-emotional development is imperative for effective intervention and support. School psychologists are uniquely positioned to assess and address students' socio-emotional needs, thereby promoting positive mental health outcomes and academic engagement. By fostering a nurturing and inclusive school climate, psychologists facilitate the cultivation of essential skills such as empathy, resilience, and conflict resolution, laying the foundation for lifelong success (Suldo & Shaffer, 2008). Moreover, the integration of social-emotional learning principles into the fabric of education aligns with broader societal goals of fostering responsible citizenship and equitable opportunities. As emphasized by Schonert-Reichl and Lawlor (2010), SEL initiatives contribute to the creation of supportive school communities that value diversity, equity, and social justice. The imperative of focusing

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on social-emotional development within the purview of school psychology cannot be overstated. By recognizing and addressing the socio-emotional needs of students, psychologists not only enhance academic outcomes but also nurture the holistic development of students.

IMPORTANCE OF SEL SKILLS

Social-emotional learning involves the development of skills like self-awareness, self-management, social awareness, relationship building, and responsible decision-making (CASEL, 2020). These skills are necessary for fostering healthy relationships, effective communication, self-regulation, and preventing harm to others (Bishop, 2023). Furthermore, research has shown that students' ability to understand and manage their emotions and relationships is linked to academic and career success (Durlak et al., 2011; Jones-Schenk, 2019; Strahan & Poteat, 2022).

Since the inception of School Psychology Review, there has been recognition of the importance of social, emotional, and behavioral development in the field of school psychology (Kohlberg, 1972; Kohn &Rosman, 1972), with increasing emphasis over the past five decades. For instance, in 2002, *School Psychology Review* featured a special issue on interventions for the social-emotional needs of children (Merrell, 2002), featuring articles highlighting that the area of social-emotional prevention and intervention activities in schools had the potential to open the door for school psychologists to focus their efforts on solving important problems. In 2010, *School Psychology Review* featured a special issue on behavioral assessment within problem-solving models (Chafouleas et al., 2010), with a focus on extending the insights of prevention-oriented multi-tiered systems of support (MTSS) in academics to social, emotional, and behavioral (SEB) domains. In 2022, *School Psychology Review* featured another special issue focused on social, emotional, and behavioral assessment within tiered decision-making frameworks (Kim et al., 2022), with a focus on reflections on the past decade of research that strengthens the psychometric evidence for use of the measures in SEB assessment.

Beginning in (2002), the journal has published a steadily increasing number of articles containing the phrase "social-emotional learning." However, in 2015 a sharp increase in publications addressing this topic began with Rose et al.'s special issue examining bullying research from a social-ecological lens. The topic continued to expand its reach in 2018 with a focus on examining diverse populations that continues today (e.g., Bottiani et al., 2018; Goforth et al., 2022; Gregory et al., 2018, Gregory et al., 2021, Jimerson et al., 2021, McCall et al., 2023; Yang & Golshirazi, 2023). Since 2018, the journal has published an average of approximately 15 articles a year examining this topic, with the SEL literature further expanding to include topics such as addressing trauma (Marraccini et al., 2023), reducing chronic school absences (Eklund et al., 2022), and integrating spirituality (Esat et al., 2024).

SEL RESEARCH AND PRACTICE

As the acquisition of social and emotional skills is crucial for healthy youth development, educators are now more aware of the importance of SEL skills and practices (Zins et al., 2007). A number of evidence-based programs have been developed to teach student SEL skills (Domitrovich et al., 2017), which have been linked to positive student outcomes, such as increased academic engagement, improved behavior, and attachment to school (Durlak et al., 2011; Zins et al., 2007). Therefore, Durlak et al. (2011) suggested that SEL should be a vital part of pre-K-12 education to provide children with systematic instruction on these crucial skills. In fact, SEL standards and practices have become increasingly embedded in schools through multi-tiered systems of support. Such systems provide services that target the prevention of social-emotional problems and the promotion of primary SEL skills for all students, as well as the remediation of more serious concerns among at-risk students (Eklund et al., 2018). The establishment and adoption of SEL standards across states have also facilitated the wide dissemination of SEL practices. This has allowed districts and schools to outline the skills children should learn and expectations of what should be taught and assessed in schools.

Despite the increasing implementation of SEL standards and practices in schools, there are still gaps within SEL research and practice that could potentially limit their practicality and effectiveness. Most of the existing SEL research has focused on critical SEL skills and their related outcomes (e.g., Ross & Tolan, 2018; Yang et al., 2018), the current status of SEL practices across schools or states (e.g., Eklund et al., 2018; Meyers et al., 2019), and SEL assessment (e.g., Elliott et al., 2018; Ura et al., 2020) and intervention (e.g., Espelage et al., 2016; LaBelle, 2023) and made significant contributions to the current knowledge of SEL in the field of school psychology. However, they also indicated that further research is required to address any remaining questions to advance our knowledge and practice. For example, while school-based SEL training and programs have been associated with positive student outcomes, limited research is available on the developmental benchmarks within core SEL competencies (Eklund et al., 2018), SEL assessment and implementation practices under typical school conditions (Hunter et al., 2018), and factors that mediate or

moderate the success of various SEL interventions (Ura et al., 2020). These critical issues need to be addressed to improve the feasibility and effectiveness of SEL practices within schools.

This special topic section aims to address some of the remaining questions related to the current status and future directions in youth SEL development. Specifically, the included articles discuss various themes such as the role of individuals (e.g., peers or teachers) or tools in contributing to the effectiveness of SEL assessments and interventions, who can benefit from the involvement in interventions, the effectiveness of existing SEL interventions on various positive student outcomes, and how an SEL framework is translated into state-wide practices to demonstrate theory informing practice. Overall, this special topic section seeks to bring together current and timely evidence that is relevant for the future path of SEL research and practice.

OVERVIEW OF ARTICLES IN THE CURRENT SPECIAL TOPIC SECTION

This special topic section includes seven articles that present recent work on SEL framework and intervention to inform practice and future research. One of the studies (Frye et al., 2024) explored how the CASEL has been incorporated into state SEL standards and school-based SEL practices. Another study (McDaniel et al., 2024) examined an observational measure of classroom management, the Assessing School Settings: Interactions of Students and Teachers (ASSIST), to measure teachers' classroom management practices and detect differences across classroom levels. Nygaard and Ormiston (2024) then discussed how school-based transitions impact the teacher ratings of the Social, Academic, and Emotional Behavior Risk Screener (SAEBRS). The remaining four studies examined the effectiveness of SEL interventions. Two of these studies (Crewdson et al., 2024; Owen-DeSchryver et al., 2024) focused on peer-mediated interventions, one (Jiang et al., 2024) focused on growth mindset interventions, and one (Morizio et al., 2024) focused on an empathy curriculum called Creating Compassion.

Frye et al. (2024) conducted an exploratory study using text mining and network graphing techniques to explore the implementation of the CASEL framework in state standards. The aim of the study was to understand how state standards reflect the CASEL framework and the SEL skills that are present and valued across states. The authors provided visual aids to explain content indicators and standard examples, as well as to demonstrate the relationships between domain indicators within each of the five CASEL domains. These resources can benefit practitioners, policymakers, and other interested parties in understanding the content of individual CASEL domains and how they are described in state standards to implement accountability measures for progress monitoring. The study also revealed a high degree of content similarity across CASEL domains in state standards, which has implications for future research and practice. Further investigation into how the five CASEL domains should be interpreted in standards can inform SEL-focused research, policy, and practice, ultimately leading to better support for students' SEL skill development.

Nygaard and Ormiston (2024) evaluated the relationship between school-based transitions, specifically from 8th to 9th grades, and teacher ratings of SAEBRS in a mid-sized suburban school district. School-based transitions are significant life events as students need to adapt to new environments, expectations, and relationships, which can increase their risk of experiencing academic and emotional difficulties. The study revealed that SAEBRS scores decreased significantly from 8th to 9th grade during the school-based transition in the total, academic, and emotional subscales. However, when transitioning from 7th to 8th grade within the same school building, SAEBRS scores increased significantly in each subscale. School psychologists can address these concerns by offering additional academic and emotional support to students in the 8th and 9th grades to reduce risk levels and help them transition to high school more successfully.

Creating a supportive and positive classroom environment requires effective management of the social, emotional, and behavioral dynamics of the classroom. Recognizing the importance of classroom management for student positive development, McDaniel et al. (2024) used the ASSIST, an observational measure, to examine differences in classroom management practices across 3,263 classroom contexts, such as class size and racial composition. The ASSIST was found to be an effective tool for measuring classroom management practices and identifying differences across classroom contexts, allowing for meaningful comparisons. The authors recommended that future research use the ASSIST as a single tool with confidence for evaluating classroom management practices across multiple classroom settings and school levels. The study also revealed that high school teachers generally employed fewer directive and praise-based strategies when compared to elementary teachers. This may indicate the need for additional professional development and coaching support for teachers in high school classrooms.

Two studies were conducted to evaluate the effectiveness of peer-mediated interventions. First, Crewdson et al. (2024) assessed the effectiveness of Tootling (i.e., teaching students to observe and report peers' positive behaviors and reinforcing these reports) on the performance of two recently trained social skills among at-risk, first-grade students. The study found that supplementing social skills

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training with a Tootling intervention showed immediate and sustained increases in compliments and encouragement when the intervention was implemented outside the social skills training environment. However, when the intervention was withdrawn, there was an immediate and sustained decrease in using the skills. The study suggests that social skills training alone may not be effective in enhancing social skills performance outside the training context, but supplementing it with Tootling interventions may address these performance deficits. While more theoretical and empirical evidence is needed, this study introduces the idea that peer-mediated interventions can enhance and maintain the performance of learned social skills among students across social contexts.

Owen-DeSchryver et al. (2024) provided new insights by evaluating the impact of peer-mediated interventions for students with autism and other developmental disabilities on their peer partners. The results showed that peer partners generally experienced positive outcomes, such as increased GPAs, better daily attendance, and decreased behavioral referrals and suspensions. This study provides evidence that peer-mediated interventions can benefit not only the targeted students with disabilities, but also their peer partners. Therefore, diverse peer partners, including those with academic and behavioral challenges, should be included in these interventions. The authors recommend further studies on research-based, peer-mediated interventions to promote educational and social outcomes for all participants.

Jiang et al. (2024) conducted the first systematic review of growth mindset interventions among school-aged children and adolescents. The final sample included 14 studies from 13 articles, which were analyzed for research quality, sample characteristics, intervention content, and intervention effects. Despite differences in quality, samples, and designs, the core content of the interventions was found to be highly similar. The results indicated that brief growth mindset interventions can lead to improved growth mindsets and social-emotional outcomes for children and adolescents. Specifically, these interventions can help reduce depressive and aggressive symptoms when individuals experience elevated social stress. The authors discussed the gaps in empirical research and methodological implications from previous intervention studies for future research. They also provided practitioners with recommendations on how to improve the quality and impact of growth mindset interventions.

Finally, Morizio et al. (2024) evaluated a combined arts and empathy training intervention called Creating Compassion. This intervention was designed as a short-term, low-cost, high-quality SEL program. The study used a multiple baseline single-case design and found that Creating Compassion increased observed prosocial behaviors and global SEL competence in early elementary students, including those with identified social-emotional skill deficits. One of the strengths of this intervention is that many of the materials required for its implementation are already available within most intervention settings. Another strength is that the SEL instruction of Creating Compassion can be easily embedded into existing art classes in schools. These strengths, combined with its effectiveness, make Creating Compassion a cost- and time-efficient alternative to many comprehensive SEL programs, which can benefit students in low-income and economically marginalized communities.

DISCUSSION AND IMPLICATIONS

Supporting student social-emotional learning and development is linked to academic, behavioral, and long-term success (Domitrovich et al., 2017; Durlak et al., 2011; Jones-Schenk, 2019; Strahan & Poteat, 2022; Taylor et al., 2017), and forms a core component of school psychological services (NASP, 2020). The six articles featured in this section underscore the importance of comprehensive and systematic SEL support and provide practical evidence for practitioners to effectively identify and implement these concepts with the diverse populations they serve. In light of the growing concerns about youth mental health, these articles are essential and empowering for school-based practitioners.

This special topic section contributes to the journal's extensive exploration of students' social-emotional learning, and the articles contained within highlight essential findings as well as areas requiring additional scholarship. The studies included here contain diverse samples from varied racial, ethnic, socio-economic, and geographic backgrounds. However, future research should aim to explore these interventions with even more diverse populations and in alternative settings. Continuing these explorations with diverse populations is a crucial step, as the broader SEL literature, while expansive, often lacks a comprehensive focus on diverse student groups. Such research is needed to gain a more thorough understanding of student well-being and contribute to improved outcomes.

Moreover, there is a need for additional scholarship that builds on the findings presented here by exploring the mechanisms of SEL intervention components with diverse populations and across settings. The associations between student SEL and positive student outcomes establish the importance of identifying factors that contribute to SEL development (LaRosa et al., 2023). Research examining these factors is warranted and will help meet the varied needs of school-based practitioners. For example, much of

the work published in SEL interventions relies upon interdependent group contingencies. As Crewdson et al. (2024) note, the supportive social nature of these types of contingencies is ideal for many of these interventions, and this component likely increases the intervention's effectiveness (Richardson et al., 2021). However, situations will arise in practice where these interdependent group contingency arrangements are infeasible, and the strength of these effects may not replicate in designs that use alternate reinforcement methods. Similarly, as many of the authors highlighted in this section note, studies expanding the generalization and maintenance effects of these studies are necessary to determine if the effects of these interventions are prevalent and maintained across settings and environments.

While further research is necessary to determine intervention effectiveness under various circumstances, it is also essential to explore the language utilized in state standards that promote effective implementation. For instance, building upon the discoveries made by Frye et al. (2024), research analyzing state standards could provide valuable service to practitioners, researchers, and policymakers by ensuring that research, policy standards, and implementation practices align. This information would help policymakers in their efforts to improve and codify state SEL standards that more accurately encompass and define areas that support and enhance SEL practices in schools and close existing gaps between research and practice.

Barriers to closing existing gaps in research are often difficult to overcome; however, with the expansion of virtual service delivery options, the effectiveness of these interventions can now more easily be incorporated and examined across settings using procedures that are less intrusive or cumbersome than traditional methods. Furthermore, the SEL framework is set to meet challenges in diversifying these interventions as it acknowledges the importance of catering to a diverse student population, nurturing their social and emotional development, and creating responsive interventions that acknowledge and address cultural and linguistic differences. These considerations will foster work that ensures diverse student populations are represented in the research and appropriately served in practice. The combination of a flexible theoretical model and new technologies opens up new possibilities and should inspire optimism about the future of SEL interventions, particularly by school psychologists and other school-based practitioners, as they work to improve the outcomes of the students and families they serve.

DISCLOSURE

The authors have no conflicts of interest to report.

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